On April 21, Kedar Suresh Chougule, a second-year B.Tech. student of Chemical Engineering at the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Madras, was found hanging in his hostel room. Ironically, his death came three days after Dharmendra Pradhan, the Union minister of education, directed the prestigious engineering institutes to provide robust mental health support for students. Pradhan was addressing the 55th meeting of the IIT Council, the highest decision-making body for the institutes, at Bhubaneswar. Chougule's was the sixth suicide on IIT campuses in the first four months of 2023. Three other students had taken their lives in IIT Madras, while another two died by suicide on the IIT Bombay and IIT Guwahati campuses during the same period.

"Academic stress, family and personal reasons and mental health issues are some of the reasons for such suicides," Subhas Sarkar, the Union minister of state for education, told Parliament on March 27. His statement came while disclosing a grim statistic: 33 students had died by suicide on IIT campuses since 2018. With two more added to this horrific tally in April, this number was one higher than the 34 students in the country's 23 IITs who died by suicide in the eight years between 2014 and 2021, another revelation that came on the floor of Parliament on December 20, 2021. And this is excluding the unsuccessful suicide attempts. On February 13, a first-year B.Tech. student attempted to kill himself at IIT Madras, the very day that Stephen Sunny, a second-year MS research scholar in Electrical Engineering, ended his life in his hostel room.

It was no surprise, therefore, that the mental health of students was the prime focus during the IIT Council meet. While emphasising the need to build a robust grievance redressal system, increasing psychological counselling services and reducing pressure, fear of failure and rejection among students, Pradhan also advocated zero tolerance for any kind of discrimination. Caste discrimination is an unacknowledged reality in the rarefied environs of the premier engineering institutes. It reared its ugly head yet again when IIT Bombay student Arman Khatri was arrested on charges of abetting the suicide of his classmate Darshan Solanki, a Dalit. In fact, of the 34 suicides between 2014 and 2021, 18 were by students from the Scheduled Caste and Other Backward Class communities. In 2021, the education ministry told the Rajya Sabha that 63 per cent of the undergraduate students who dropped out of the top seven IITs were from the backward category.

WHAT'S FUELLING THE TREND?

From high societal expectations for academic performance, peer pressure, inability to cope with the rigorous schedules, language barriers, increasing class sizes, caste discrimination, little personal connect with faculty to poor outreach by on-campus counsellors, a whole host of factors may contribute to the spike in suicidal tendencies. Students typically react to the high-pressure environment in two ways—they either get extremely competitive or go into a depressive phase. While those with strong social and economic support systems find it easier to deal with the ecosystem, others are more vulnerable. "These days," says an IIT professor, "most of those who come to the IITs have been through coaching centres

UNION EDUCATION MINISTER DHARMENDRA PRADHAN HAS STRESSED THE NEED FOR A ROBUST GRIEVANCE REDRESSAL SYSTEM AND INCREASING PSYCHOLOGICAL COUNSELLING SERVICES AT IITs

